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Trapped in Memory

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Imagine the busy streets of Paris during the roaring 20s, where gentlemen roamed the cobblestone streets in their suits, passing by the rebellious women in their flapper dresses. Once the rain begins pouring and the orange streetlights awaken, the town fills with the smell of warm nutmeg, vanilla, and the intoxicating scent of a cigarette as the soulful funk of jazz is heard from the dimly lit cafes surrounding the city.

For struggling writer Gil Pender, this was the golden age of Paris, which filled the void of the early 2010s. *Midnight in Paris* – by director Woody Allen – follows Gil as he unexpectedly travels back in time to the 1920s, a revolutionary period in history for writers and artists. During his nightly visits, he encounters famous artists residing in France such as F. Scott Fitzgerald, Pablo Picasso, Ernest Hemmingway and Cole Porter, whose creative work leads Gil further into his romanticize of Paris. He monologues that in the cold, and seemingly meaningless universe, the hottest and most unique spot is Paris (51:00). His illusions grow stronger throughout the film until he meets his lover, Adriana, who depicts Belle Époque as her perfect time. When they travel back to that era in the Moulin Rouge, they discover that the artists of the 1890s desire to be a part of the Renaissance, leading to this never-ending search for nostalgia among every generation.

Adriana's admission that the 1920s are dull and uninteresting shatters Gil's Golden Age Thinking, which is the belief that a previous era was superior to the present, usually motivated by nostalgia and a desire to escape one's current issues. The idea of a 'Golden Age,' as a time of idealized past existence, originates all the way from Greek mythology, meaning that this isn't a foreign concept. Since nostalgia is more than just personal longing, it begs the question: how can our perception of history become distorted? By analyzing the psychological, cultural, and political functions of nostalgia, we can gain a better understanding of why individuals mentally

restructure history to meet their emotional needs. Although nostalgia is deceptively complex, a complete analysis reveals why people reminisce through rose-tinted glasses, seeing the reality they want to escape from the truth.

TYPES OF NOSTALGIA

Svetlana Boym was a Russian-American theorist and author of *The Future of Nostalgia*, a book about her lived experience of exile after the fall of the Soviet Union. She tore down the concept of nostalgia into two not mutually exclusive categories, restorative and reflective. Restorative nostalgia is the desire to restore a time that one longs to be a part of, or simply, to return home (Boym 8). Boym explains that restorative nostalgia takes itself “dead seriously” (19), often contributing to the mental rebuilding of monuments of the past. Reflective nostalgia focuses on the individual's culture and memory, whereby they linger in the past with no attempt to change it, instead reflecting. Boym explains that while restorative nostalgia almost always appears to be a loss of something in the past, reflective nostalgia can be positive, “ironic and humorous” (19). Gil’s yearning for the 1920s reveals that restorative nostalgia has the power to cloud judgment and isolate individuals.

The parallels between Adriana and Gil’s idea of the golden age depict the flaw of individual nostalgia, more so explaining that our preconceived notions of a certain time are only our subjective views. Gil argues with Adriana that the 1920s are perfect and moving into the 1890s with Henri de Toulouse-Lautrec, Paul Gauguin, and Edgar Degas – artists of the Belle Époque – won't make her happier because the people of that time only wish to be a part of the Renaissance and those people might be happier in some earlier period (1:21:17). Each person in history only sees what they’ve missed and not what they have. For the restorative nostalgic who lives in the memories of the past, it is evident that nostalgia turns history into a personal fantasy.

ROMANTICIZED HISTORY

Going back to this image of Paris as a beautiful figure of elegance and light, would it be surprising to discover that 1920s France was not as conflict-free as Gil imagines? Despite winning World War I, France suffered economic loss and devastation with over 1.4 million Frenchmen killed and destruction brought upon the land and infrastructure, as well as the Spanish Flu, which killed roughly 280,000 at the beginning of the decade. The political spectrum and identity of France as a country also weren't doing well with frequent divisions and changes in government power throughout the country (IGBIS IBDP and MYP Individuals and Societies). Even the artists in Paris felt the hardships, such as cynicism from the war, censorship, gender inequality, and racial discrimination among African American artists and writers. This tendency to project fantasy onto the past isn't limited to individuals like Gil; entire political movements have capitalized on this emotional, impulsive behavior.

Donald Trump's "Make America Great Again" slogan was wildly successful for the republican party, but a further inquiry towards those republicans as to when America was "great" leads to uncoordinated answers ranging from the 1890s – 1960s (TIME). MAGA is a deliberately vague movement allowing people to fill it in with their own version of the "golden age," just like Gil. As history often repeats itself, Boym mentions, "Indeed, much of twentieth-century violence, from pogroms to Nazi and Stalinist terror to McCarthy's Red scare, operated in response to conspiracy theories in the name of its restored homeland" (Boym 13). In political climates, restorative nostalgia is designed to influence violence amongst people based on their images of the past. But how does nostalgia have such an influence on us if we are aware that it can be so easily deceiving? We must examine why people yearn for the past initially to begin to understand its impact and influence.

EMOTIONAL TRIGGERS

Nostalgia can form in various ways, one of which is through emotional triggers such as stress, anxiety, joy, or depression. Assume most people are aware that emotions are misleading, often being the reason for impulsive decision-making or reactions; it isn't surprising that our feelings have a direct correlation to the way we think. Stress is a very common gateway to nostalgia, allowing a person to enter this state of bliss and relaxation to avoid the difficulties of their life.

In the film, Gil Pender continuously argues with his wife, Inez, about where to live after their honeymoon, which further exposes the cracks in their failing relationship. Furthermore, her friends and parents endlessly belittle him, suggesting that Inez could do better. His shame and awkwardness directly correlate to Boym's expanded definition for nostalgia, as "history without guilt" (4), meaning that nostalgia can erase uncomfortable truths. He is depicted as an unassuming, mild-mannered introvert set on living in perpetual denial instead of participating in mundane activities with his family. In doing so, he becomes out of touch with his reality as he assimilates into this fabrication. It is only revealed how far lost he is in this world when 1920s American novelist and poet, Gertrude Stein, criticizes the main character in his book – who resembles Gil in action and manner – for being unaware that his wife is cheating on him (1:24:32). His dissatisfaction with life, shallow relationships, and failing career all attributed to his longing for a simpler time. Boym agrees that "The danger of nostalgia is that it tends to confuse the actual home and the imaginary one." (6), which explains Gil's behavior during the film, often seen partying in the 20s yet refusing to go dancing in the present.

This emotional instability not only distorts Gil's memory but also creates this intense desire for belonging. He recognizes the 1920s or *les Années folles*, the "Crazy Years", in which

writers like him flourished, as a world where literary intellectuals like him were revered. Gil discovers a community that affirms his values and ambitions. Unlike his reality, where he feels like an outsider, he is seen in the past for who he presents himself to be. It is important to note that I intentionally do not say “for who he is” because this version of Gil is inauthentic to his actual life. His nostalgia extends to not only a lost time, but a lost identity.

MEANING THROUGH MEMORY

There is no question that people want to fit into certain places, economically, socially, and/or creatively. It is our natural human response to want to be a part of something greater than the sum of its parts. *Midnight in Paris* does an excellent job of showing Gil’s gripe with his placement in the universe. He even questions his relationship saying, “I’m engaged to marry a woman I love. At least, I think I love her. Christ! I better love her! I’m marrying her!” (57:18). He is lost in the life he has been thrown into, which isn’t far off from the identity crises many people face.

In this way, nostalgia becomes a symptom of existential instability. A way to run away from the fear of our lives, lacking meaning. Gil searches for spiritual significance in his life through literature, which is why the 1920s are as appealing as they are to him. It isn’t just artistic representation but also identity and purpose that lead him to the 1920s. Gertrude Stein offers some direct wisdom to Gil: “We all fear death and question our place in the universe. The artist’s job is not to succumb to despair, but to find an antidote for the emptiness of existence” (1:02:10). This line resonates with Gil and resembles the fear of the average person, because nostalgia is seductive in its romanticization of what could have been, and we often forget about what we can do. Rather than creating a true meaning in the present, it traps us in our minds, roaming through

a past that never existed. Stein deciphers the antidote to despair as not retreat, but creation. Not memory but meaning.

But does this mean that we should live in fear of nostalgia? By remembering, do we open ourselves to weakness? Should we always choose creation over memories? These are all questions worth asking because many people find joy in nostalgia instead of delusions. Memories offer healing, remorse, and even growth. Sometimes visiting the past isn't about escaping the present but instead anchoring ourselves for the future.

CALL TO ACTION

At this point, it may sound like this is a fear-mongering tactic used to prevent the masses from even thinking about remembering, but like everything in life, it is a wide spectrum. Nostalgia isn't something to fear; it is something to understand. Boym reminds us, "Nostalgia is not always about the past; it can be retrospective but also prospective. The past imagined within nostalgia might be better than the present, but not necessarily worse than the future" (14). In other words, instead of looking to find something in the past, we can instead use nostalgia to observe what we still lack in the present. If we do live in fear of nostalgia, then we never confront ourselves and instead hide in our shadows. Nostalgia doesn't arise from weakness; it grows from fear. The fear of emotional instability, emptiness, or a future devoid of purpose.

The point that I must emphasize is that this fear does not have to guide us into delusion. Reflective nostalgia can appreciate one's memories while still facing the pain of the past. Instead of assuming the past is flawless, reflection allows us to see it for what it is. It serves as a reminder that our story is part of a larger narrative, not bound by a specific time. So yes, happiness matters. Sometimes happiness comes from memories or fragments of history that

make us who we are, and we must never forget who we are. If we want that joy of nostalgia to last, then we need to carry the light and the dark with the same strength. The reason for our vices for restoration stem from our emotions, our sense of belonging, and our criticism of our current time. The phrase “Comparison is the thief of joy” applies not just to individuals, but to time itself. Often, getting comfortable in the past only leads to one’s own downfall once they begin to criticize seemingly mundane aspects of their real life. However, nostalgia’s influence doesn’t end at the individual level, having the ability to infiltrate the perception of our romantic relationships.

NOSTALGIA’S TRAP

Social media motivational creator Philosophaire wrote a poem saying, “Nostalgia is a beautiful liar. It shows you highlight reels, while hiding all the reasons things ended. You scroll through old photos, replay conversations, and convince yourself that what's gone was better than what remains. But clinging to memories keeps you trapped between worlds, physically here but mentally living in moments that no longer exist” (Philosophaire). This is restorative nostalgia at its peak, demonstrating the loss and pain of an emotional breakup, leaving one party longing for the other’s return. The sentence, “convince yourself that what's gone was better than what remains,” is important to highlight the relatable coping mechanisms many people experience, especially after their first heartbreak.

Philosophaire’s poetry aligns with the views of Boym as she writes, “The nostalgic desires to obliterate history and turn it into private or collective mythology, to revisit time like space, refusing to surrender to the irreversibility of time that plagues the human conditions” (Boym 5). Boym echoes the warning that nostalgia alters the passage of time, turning selective moments into personal truths. Philosophaire illustrates how the same thing happens in personal relationships after heartbreak. In both cases, nostalgia obscures the endings of stories and offers

emotional comfort. While this emotional distortion may still seem purely individual, nostalgia does interact with memory at the expense of others.

SELECTIVE MEMORY

Nostalgia is not equal or universal. It often comforts one group while undermining the pain of another. History has been unfavorable towards certain groups throughout its time. Specifically, African Americans have been at the forefront of racial discrimination, prejudice, and exclusion for ongoing, extensive periods of American history. For many white Baby Boomers and Generation X Americans, who align with more conservative values, the 1950s are regarded as a golden age in America. Economic stability, traditional family values, and social order contribute to this romanticization. Yet African Americans remember that era through Jim Crow segregation, housing and social discrimination, legal inequality, and racial violence.

This contrast reflects what Eduardo Bonilla-Silva calls “color-blind racism”, an ideology that perpetuates racial inequality by selectively remembering a past that was only comfortable for a dominant group (Bonilla 2). As Bonilla-Silva explains in *Racism Without Racists*, white nostalgia often highlights the privileges associated with the past while ignoring the structural and systemic issues that denied those same privileges to Black Americans. This nostalgia becomes a “collective mythology” as Boym mentions (Boym 5) that allows some to mourn the loss of a golden past, while ignoring the injustices that others lived through. Memories are altered to fit our narratives, but they can become worse when the interactions of our memories are provided to an algorithm.

DIGITAL NOSTALGIA

As times change, so do the predatory tactics that are used to exploit human behavior. Media has taken over the modern world, evolving from a way to communicate into a business model. Companies have learned how to weaponize and market nostalgia and have increasingly begun to incorporate nostalgic features in social media services. Social media applications like Snapchat, TikTok, and Instagram have developed features called “Spotlight”, “On This Day”, or “Memories” that show archived photos and videos from years in the past. On the surface, these features seem harmless, but the motivations behind these additions reveal deeper capitalistic purposes.

Corporations understand that people tend to spend a lot of time reflecting on their experiences, especially during times of heightened stress and uncertainty, as depicted by Boym and Gil. By resurfacing old memories, users become more engaged and tend to stay online for longer. The longer a user stays on a platform, the more ads they see, leading to more income and engagement for the corporation. As Katrina Niemeyer writes in *Media and Nostalgia*, “Media, and new technologies in particular, can function as platforms, project places and tools to express nostalgia,” (Niemeyer 7) turning a once exciting memory into a trick for profit. This deliberate algorithmic feature has locked users into a term called “doom scrolling”, or endless consumption of addictive content that stimulates the dopamine receptors of users. This predatory behavior intentionally makes it harder to resist the effect of history on our memories.

CONCLUSION

Nostalgia shapes individuals and societies by interpreting the past and influencing behavior, identity, and even politics. While it is effective at distorting memories, leading to unrealistic perceptions of history, nostalgia can provide comfort and insight into the present day.

Midnight in Paris, *The Future of Nostalgia*, and other works understand that nostalgia isn't strictly detrimental or beneficial, but a large idea that can explain emotional and cultural experiences. By understanding the complexities of nostalgia through history, we open the room for more conversation, such as ethics in social media. Navigating between the past and present can be done without an attempt to escape and while maintaining authenticity.

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